

tiding IT OVER

✱ **Technology Informatics Design Endeavour**

Project Taking technology to the grassroots

Can-do Icon Prof.

Amulya Reddy of IISc, who showed how challenging rural problems could be

74 per cent

of rural Indian households use firewood as cooking fuel

A four-and-half-hour drive away from Bangalore lies Tiptur, a hamlet of 53,043 people. The villagers here may not have the resources to fulfil their every whim, but they stand head and shoulders above everyone else when it comes to using technology. And helping deliver it to them is the Technology Informatics Design Endeavour, or TIDE,

created by 20 professionals at Bangalore in 1993 after leaving their comfortable jobs.

Following 14 years with the Karnataka State Council for Science and Technology (KSCST), Santhanagopalan Rajagopalan, the founder-chairman of TIDE, along with some friends and colleagues, decided to venture down a path less-trodden—taking

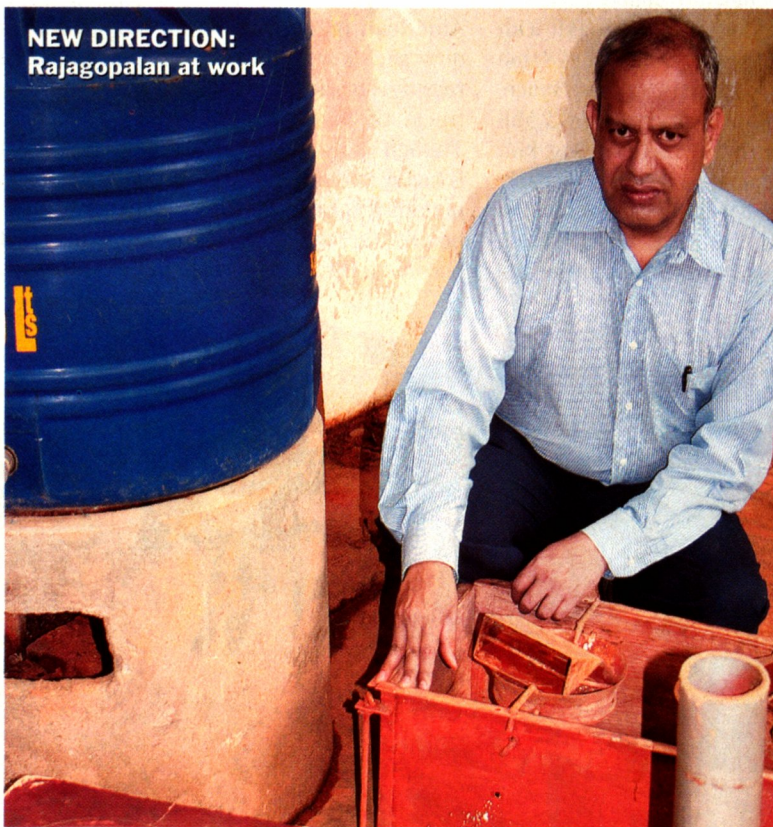
technology to the grassroots. “We felt the need for a new mechanism outside government for the dissemination of technologies that are economical, attractive, ecologically sustainable and socially acceptable,” says Rajagopalan.

Setting aside the traditional technology transfer model of “lab to land”, TIDE ensured that technology grows by being appropriated by many partners. With an annual budget of Rs 1 crore, over the last 15 years TIDE has contributed various renewable energy technologies like stoves, dryers, kilns, bioreactors, rainwater harvesting structures, vermi-compost plants and municipal waste composting plants. Today, 60,000 individual users, 8,000 rural enterprises and 3,000 rural households have adopted more than 100 TIDE technologies in areas like Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu and Kerala. “These technologies help cut processing costs, increase productivity and quality of products, and also reduce emissions,” says Rajagopalan. “They also help reduce the use of firewood and other biomass by as much as 15,000 tonne per year.

Despite systematic plans of action, dealing with the challenges out there isn’t easy for TIDE. The mindset of rural customers, corruption in the administrative and regulatory systems that prevent entrepreneurs from accessing government programmes and the issue of transforming engineers and scientists into sensitive enterprise builders remain the crux of their problem.

Headquartered in the south at present, TIDE’s plan is to expand gradually into the north of India, keeping intact their goal of weaning the rural customer away from benefits, subsidies and support while moulding them into market-ready consumers who are ready to pay for quality services.

by Purvi Malhotra



NEW DIRECTION:
Rajagopalan at work

SANJAY RAMACHANDRAN

“Fulfilting the needs of the neediest is not only rewarding but gives one a high.”

S. RAJAGOPALAN, Chairman, TIDE